A Long Way Gone: Memoirs of a Boy Soldier

By Ishmael Beah

My high school friends have begun to suspect I haven't told them the full story of my life.

FRIEND: Why did you leave Sierra Leone?

ISHMAEL: Because there was a war.

FRIEND: You saw people running around with guns and shooting each other?

ISHMAEL: Yes, all the time.

FRIEND: *Cool.*

INTRODUCTION

It is, perhaps, one of the most important war stories of our time. In over twenty countries around the world, children as young as 7 years old are serving as child soldiers. And not just a few of them either – more than 300,000 boys are fighting in current armed conflicts. They wield AK-47s and M-16s, serve as human mine detectors, and participate in suicide missions. Many of these children are abducted or recruited by force. Others join out of desperation, believing it is their best chance for survival.

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In this true story, author Ishmael Beah tells how he became one of them. He was only 12 when rebel forces attacked his Sierra Leone village in 1998. Separated from his family, Ishmael spent months searching for them. In this scene, he and his fellow child soldiers approach a village where their families are said to be in hiding.

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ALHAJI: I look forward to getting to this village. Ah, I will give my mother a very tight hug. *(smiles)* She always complains, though, when I give her a tight hug: 'If you love me, stop squeezing my old bones so I can be alive longer.' She is funny.

KANEI: I have a feeling that we will find our families, or at least news of them.

Finally, we were approaching the village where seeing our families was actually a possibility. I couldn't stop smiling. We came across a man cutting down ripe bananas. The sight of his face awakened my memory. He was much skinnier than when I had last seen him. His

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name was Gasemu – Ngor Gasemu. *(Ngor is a title like "Mr.")*

GASEMU: *(Peeps at them from behind a banana leaf. Wipes the sweat off his forehead and walks toward them. Smiles.)*

You boys want to help me carry some bananas to the village?

(asks in the manner that adults usually ask young people when they won't take no for an answer.) Come on. *(Motions for them to follow him into the banana farm. Continues waving his hand.) (speaks to Ishmael)*

Are you still a troublesome boy?

ISHMAEL: There is no time to be troublesome these days.

GASEMU: Your parents and brothers will be happy to see you. They have been talking about you every day and praying for your safety. Your mother cries every day. Your older brother left to look for you, but he returned about a week ago. His face was sad when he returned. I think he blames himself for losing you.

4NG Fanatics

I wanted to drop the bananas and run as fast as I could to the village. I felt as if my heart would explode if I waited any longer.

GASEMU: The village is just over the hill.

I heard gunshots. And dogs barking. And people screaming and crying. We dropped the bananas and began running. A thick smoke started rising from the village. Nails were popping off tin roofs, and they flew landing on nearby thatched roofs, increasing the wrath of the fire. We heard screams and loud banging a few houses away. There were people locked in it. We banged the door open, but it was too late. Only two people came out, a woman and a young child. They were on fire, and ran up and down the village, slamming themselves against everything in their way. The woman fell and stopped moving. The child gave a loud screech and sat next to a tree. He stopped moving. It all happened so fast that we just stood there, rooted to the ground. The child's yelp

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was still echoing in my head, as if it had taken on a life of its own inside me.

On other paths of the village were the half-burnt remains of those who had fought fiercely to free themselves, only to die outside. I hesitantly tried to make out the faces of burnt bodies, but it was impossible to tell who they had been. Besides, there were too many of them.

GASEMU: Your family stayed in that house. *(Pointing toward one of the charred houses.)*

The fire had consumed all the door and window frames. *(His entire body goes into shock. Only his eyes move, slowly opening and closing. He falls to the ground, holding his face. He gets up and runs toward the house. Without any fear, he goes inside and looks around the smoke-filled rooms. He screams at the top of his lungs and begins to cry as loudly as he can, punching and kicking with all his might into the weak walls that continue to burn.)*

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My hands and feet punched and kicked the burning walls, but I couldn't feel a thing. Gasemu and the rest of the other boys began pulling me away from the house.

Soon we heard loud voices of people approaching the village. We ran into the nearby coffee farm and lay in the dirt watching. A group of more than ten rebels were laughing and giving each other high fives. Two looked slightly older than me – maybe 13 or 14. They had blood on their clothes, and one of them carried the head of a man, which he held by the hair. Blood dripped from where the neck had once been. The other rebel carried a gallon of gasoline and a big box of matches.

REBEL 1: We burned three villages today. *(laughing)*

REBEL 2: Yes, three is impressive, in just a few hours in the afternoon. *(pauses)* I especially enjoyed burning this village. We caught everyone here. No one escaped. That is how

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good it was. Commander will be pleased when he gets here. *(nods)*

REBEL 1: Some people escaped in the other two villages. *(pauses, rubs his forehead as if pondering why that had happened.)* They probably saw the smoke from this village and knew something was happening. We should change our strategy. Next time we must attack all the villages at the same time.

I had heard from adults that this was a revolutionary war, a liberation of the people from corrupt government. But what kind of liberation movement shoots *(and burns)* innocent civilians, children?

We escaped the village and ran to the forest. We must have been walking for days, I do not really remember, when suddenly two men put us at gunpoint and motioned, with their guns, for us to come closer. They were the soldiers – not the rebels. There were four men lying on the ground, their uniforms soaked with blood. I turned away, and my eyes caught the smashed

4NG Fanatics

head of another man. I felt nauseated. Everything began to spin around me. One of the soldiers was looking at me *(smiling).* He took a drink from his water bottle and threw the remaining water at my face.

SOLDIER: You will get used to it; everybody does eventually.

The soldier led us to Yele, a village that was occupied by the military. In the beginning, it seemed we had finally found safety there. The village was full of lively chattering and laughter. All that darkened the mood of the village was the sight of orphaned children. There were over thirty boys between the ages of seven and sixteen. I was one of them.

One morning the atmosphere in the village suddenly became tense. It wasn't clear what had caused the change, but something was about to happen. I was awake when the soldiers left in the middle of the night. The following morning, wounded soldiers were brought back only to die by lamplit surgery. Prisoners were lined

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up and shot in the head. These things went on for many days, and each time the soldiers went to the front lines, few returned. The lieutenant asked his men to gather everyone at the square.

(in the voice of the Lieutenant): In the forest there are men waiting to destroy all of our lives. We have fought them as best as we can, but there are too many of them. They are all around the village. *(Makes a circle in the air with his hands.)* They won't give up until they capture this village. They want our food and ammunition. *(Pauses, and slowly continues.)* Some of you are here because they have killed your parents or families; others because this is a safe place to be. Well, it is not that safe anymore. That is why we need strong men and boys to help us fight. If you do not want to fight or help, that is fine. But you will not have rations and will not stay in this village. This is your time to revenge the deaths of your families and to make sure more children do not lose theirs.

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We had no choice. Leaving the village was as good as being dead. The women and older people in the village stood on their verandahs and watched as we were led away by the adult soldiers into the clearing toward the forest. A baby cried uncontrollably in his mother's arms, as if he knew what lay ahead of us.

I have never been so afraid to go anywhere in my life as I was that day. Tears had begun to form in my eyes, but I struggled to hide them and gripped my gun for comfort. The lieutenant had passed the word down through a whisper: "Fire on my command." As we watched, a group of men dressed in civilian clothes emerged. Some were boys, as young as we were. The lieutenant gave the order to fire. I lay there unable to shoot. The forest had begun to spin. *(clutches the base of a tree with one hand.)* I couldn't think, but I could hear the sounds of the guns far away in the distance and the cries of people dying in pain. A splash of blood hit my face. *(spits it out, wipes his face)* I saw the soldier it had come from. Blood poured out of the bullet holes in him like water rushing through newly opened tributaries. He

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cried for his mother in the most painfully piercing voice I had ever heard.

My face, my hands, my shirt and gun were covered with blood. I raised my gun and pulled the trigger, and I killed a man. Suddenly, as if someone was shooting them inside my brain, all the massacres I had seen since the day I was touched by war began flashing in my head. I angrily pointed my gun into the swamp and killed more people. I shot everything that moved. We went out two more times that week, and I had no problem shooting my gun. The idea of death didn't cross my mind at all, and killing had become as easy as drinking water. My mind had not only snapped during the first killing, it had also stopped making remorseful records.

We practiced killing prisoners. We were supposed to slice their throats on the corporal's command. The person whose prisoner died quickest would win the contest. I didn't feel a thing for my prisoner, didn't think that much about what I was doing. I just waited for the corporal's order. The prisoner was simply another rebel who was responsible for the death of my

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family, as I had come to truly believe. The corporal gave the signal with a pistol shot and I grabbed the man's head and slit his throat in one fluid motion. I was the winner.

CLOSING

At age 16, Ishmael Beah was removed from the fighting by UNICEF. He was brought to New York City, where he graduated from high school and earned a college degree. Today, he serves as a member of various human rights groups, having spoken before the United Nations, the Council on Foreign Relations, and the Center for Emerging Threats and Opportunities. Through the help of a rehabilitation center, Ishmael has learned how to forgive himself, to regain his humanity, and, finally, to heal.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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